THE MANIPUR IMPASSE

- **Legal ambiguity around the Governor's authority to delay the assembly session may have pushed the Centre to impose President's Rule**
- **Biren's resignation was to be a strategic move to pre-empt a legal and political crisis that could have embarrassed the party**
- **News that Biren's voice was a 93% match in the audio tape where he allegedly admits to instigating the violence shocked the party**
- **Central rule may only exacerbate the wounds inflicted over the past 21 months. Ethnic divisions remain as stark as ever**

encroachments, widely seen as targeting the Kuki-dominated areas, only deepened the divide—a charge he strenuously denied. Yet, while his stand made him an enemy among the Kukis, it reinforced his standing with the Meitei electorate, which dominates the 60-member assembly with 40 seats from the valley.

The BJP's dilemma was clear: removing Biren risked alienating the Meiteis, who make up over half of Manipur's population, while keeping him in power further alienated the Kukis—including BJP's own Kuki MLAs, who blamed him for the violence. The ex-CM's defiant post now suggests he won't exit quietly, making the Centre's job even harder.

Biren's departure was not an act of owning moral responsibility for his actions. The BJP, which had steadfastly shielded him all along, was finally forced into action when internal discontent reached a breaking point, particularly after assembly speaker Thokchom Satyabrata Singh, in the words of a BJP insider, "turned rogue". Party MLAs opposed to Biren, sensing an opening, had threatened to back a no-confidence motion by the Congress. With Biren realising he had the support of only around 20 of the 52 NDA MLAs (in the 60-member house), the high command thought it fit to orchestrate his exit.

Thus the central leadership had another concern: ensuring that Manipur's assembly session, set for February 10, did not become a stage for political humiliation. To neutralise the threat, Governor Ajay Kumar Bhalla—considered a close Modi confidant—revoked the assembly session. This move effectively shut down any immediate opposition challenge, ensuring that the BJP remained in control, even if temporarily leaderless.

Another trigger came from a Supreme Court-ordered forensic investigation into a leaked audio tape allegedly featuring Biren, in which he purportedly admitted to instigating violence. The February 3 revelation that the voice in the recording had a 93 per cent match with Biren's sent shockwaves through the party. Heightening concerns in the BJP central leadership, the potential legal ramifications made his continuation as CM untenable. Biren's resignation, then, was also a strategic move to pre-empt a legal and political crisis and further embarrassment.

THE BJP, DESPITE ITS ASSEMBLY MAJORITY, FOUND IT HARD TO FIND A CONSENSUS REPLACEMENT, MAKING PRESIDENT'S RULE INEVITABLE

The BJP, despite having a clear majority in the assembly, struggled to find a consensus replacement, making President's Rule inevitable. However, the next course of action is not without its complications.

It would mean the Union government taking direct control, a move that risks alienating both Meitei and Kuki-Zo groups. The ethnic divisions that split Manipur into two distinct regions—the Meitei-controlled Imphal Valley and the Kuki-dominated hill districts—remain as stark as ever. The Kuki-Zo community continues to demand a separate administration, citing the irreversibility of the ethnic conflict.

The Meitei population, meanwhile, remains deeply anxious about demographic security. Meitei hardliners, who viewed Biren as their protector, may perceive his removal as a weakening of their political influence. For the Centre, Biren was a convenient scapegoat—even as law and order remained under its direct watch, with the state's top cop and chief secretary reporting to the Union home ministry. The prolonged failure to restore peace and stability was laid squarely at his feet.

Armed groups and civilian vigilantes—both Meitei and Kuki—roam unfettered by the state's official security apparatus. Many tote weapons looted from the state armouries. Without a decisive crackdown and demobilisation, any political solution will be cosmetic at best. The mass displacement of communities has also created entrenched distrust. The state's economy is in free fall, and daily life remains disrupted. Rebuilding trust requires tangible measures, from economic rehabilitation packages to ensuring fair representation of both communities in governance structures.

The political fallout of this crisis could be far-reaching. The BJP's credibility in Manipur is under great strain and with no immediate political resolution in sight, the state may be looking at prolonged central rule. Whether the BJP can salvage its position and restore a functioning government soon or whether fresh elections become inevitable will depend on the political manoeuvring of the BJP top leadership. For now, Manipur will remain a state in limbo, waiting for the next move in a long, unforgiving game of political chess. ■